CINEMA ▼

HER SECOND ACT

Best known for championing independent cinema, **Mauli Singh** finds renewed faith in her acting ambitions with the award-winning Punjabi drama *Birds in the Dark*

For most, Mauli Singh is the wonder woman who champions independent cinema as a publicist. Her client list includes filmmakers Rima Das, Anuparna Roy and Kanu Behl. But she has also been quietly stepping into a new role—as an actor. *Birds in the Dark*, a Punjabi drama she co-produced as well as features in, has won the Songwon Vision Audience Award and the New Currents Award at the Busan International Film Festival.



A NEW ROLE Mauli Singh (second from left) plays a Dalit farmhand and activist

The unexpected wins and the red-carpet experience have left Mauli on cloud nine. "The film has given me visibility as an actor and faith in my own abilities," she tells INDIA TODAY.

Mauli plays Dilraj Kaur, a Dalit farm labourer and activist whose quiet resilience is the moral and emotional spine of the film. Her Dilraj toils in the fields, battles for a wronged friend and advocates for equality and justice for her peers. Under Shashank Walia's adept direction, Mauli does so, most often, with her eyes and with restraint. "In the initial draft, he had envisioned Dilraj as a more vocal activist, with more spunk," she says. "But as the script evolved, she became someone who internalises her emotions and is very calm—which is so not me." That Shashank, also a talented cinematographer, has captured pastoral Punjab entirely in black and white makes the film all the more enticing.

Mauli waited for a year before she was confirmed for the part. But, before that, Shashank and producer Reema Kaur needed her expertise to help raise funds. Mauli took the pitch document to multiple studios and individuals, and finally was able to bring Hansal Mehta's True Story Films on board.

It's taken Mauli a while to get this kind of adulation. Acting was what she always yearned for, but couldn't pursue. "I was hiding my acting aspiration from everyone, including myself," she says. The creative spark was lit again when she produced Ajitpal Singh's *Fire in the Mountains* and acted in Gurvinder Singh's little-seen indie *Adh Chanani Raat*. With *Birds in the Dark*, she has found her old love again. And she is already off to shoot her next—a web series helmed by Mehta. ■

—Suhani Singh

THE LISTI

Theatrical and OTT relea



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Ramayana: Part 1

Said to have cost around Rs 4,000 crore, the two-part *Ramayana* is a colossal financial gamble for its makers—co-producers Namit Malhotra and Yash, the Kannada superstar who plays Ravan. Ranbir Kapoor and Sai Pallavi play Ram and Sita, respectively, while Sunny Deol takes on the role of Hanuman. The music is composed by A.R. Rahman and Hans Zimmer.

